

Breaking the Mold: Elsa Schiaparelli's Journey Beyond Couture and Gender Boundaries

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1. Abstract

Elsa Schiaparelli stands as a revolutionary figure, shaping not just fashion but also challenging established gender norms over the past decades. This research follows her childhood in great detail, shedding light on the unorthodox route that led to the development of her unique design philosophy. A concentrated look at the 1930s reveals Schiaparelli's groundbreaking designs, which not only challenged traditional gender norms but also contributed to a more inclusive fashion landscape.

The article highlights Elsa's partnerships with well-known Surrealist artists and the resulting fusion of art and fashion as we follow her career. An analysis of Schiaparelli's lasting impact on fashion trends reveals her contributions that continue to subvert gender stereotypes. A creative person's enduring influence must be examined in order to fully comprehend their impact. This paper explores this idea by examining Schiaparelli's resurgence under Daniel Roseberry.

The study draws comparisons between the historical circumstances of Schiaparelli's time and the present, highlighting the timeless qualities of Schiaparelli's work and its ongoing relevance. By doing this, it hopes to shed light on Schiaparelli's contributions' historical significance as well as their ongoing influence on modern fashion and the larger social discourse surrounding gender norms.

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3. Introduction

Schiaparelli's designs deliberately subverted traditional notions of beauty—fanciful, bizarre, and irreverent ideas that she developed early in life. - Lindsay Talbot, 2012

Elsa Schiaparelli, a renowned designer of the 1920s, 1930s, and 1940s, was renowned for her surrealist style, which emphasized eccentricity, color, and playfulness. Famous Hollywood icons like Katharine Hepburn and Marlene Dietrich became fans of hers due to her irreverence and eye for the unusual. She also collaborated with many artists, most notably Salvador Dali. Like many modern artists, Schiaparelli built upon art from the past as well as reacting against it. (*Elsa Schiaparelli: How I came up with my first ever design. (n.d.).*)

Her designs follow trends in women's fashion that had been developing for decades. In the late 1800s, the tone of fashion was for the most part set by women of the upper classes. It was these women who had the time, money and reason to pursue high fashion. Clothing mirrored the strict stratification of Victorian society where clothes indicated social position. Full dress functions were an important part of high society protocol. Like society, the acceptable fashion for these events was artificial and rigidly prescribed. With her early collections, Schiaparelli readily accepted the idea of comfort and practicality in the design of women's clothing, using suits, sportswear and the evening gown as the basis for her collections.

Yet Elsa reacted against the simplicity and muted color palette of Chanel and many other contemporary designers with her use of bold, contrasting colors, including a "shocking" pink of her own invention. She introduced whimsical decorations, patterns and accessories to the world of fashion, showing gowns decorated with lobsters, newsprint or cancelled stamp patterns, buttons in the shape of tiny snails and collars made from feathers and monkey fur.

4. Early life & Career

4.1. Background & Upbringing

Elsa Schiaparelli, born on September 10, 1890, into a privileged family in Rome, Italy, experienced a culturally rich upbringing. She grew up in an aristocratic and intellectual family, with a father who was the director of the Lincei library and a professor of Oriental literature, an astronomer uncle, and a mother descended from the Medicis. Surrounded by intellectuals, Elsa decided to repress her desire to be an actress and pursued philosophy. In 1911, she published a collection of overtly sensual poems, *Arethusa*. When her parents found out, she was sent to a convent in Switzerland, from which she later returned after going on hunger strike.

Despite coming from a wealthy family, Schiaparelli had a pivotal moment during World War I when she visited London and experienced the free-spirited culture that would eventually shape her avant-garde style of dressing. It was in London actually that she met her husband, Count William de Wendt de Kerlor, a theosophist and one of her lecturer. They moved to New York and had a daughter, Maria Luisa Yvonne Radha de Wendt de Kerlor - better known as Gogo Schiaparelli.

(Huene, G. H. (n.d.). Maison Schiaparelli - the life of fashion designer Elsa Schiaparelli.)



Image Source : Getty Images

4.2. Initial steps into fashion

- Schiaparelli began working with Gaby Picabia in New York; she was the proprietor of a store in the city that sold French clothing and the ex-wife of French Dadaist artist Francis Picabia. Schiaparelli made the acquaintance of artists Marcel Duchamp and Man Ray while working there. Upon the dissolution of her marriage due to her husband's adultery, she made the decision to accompany Man Ray and Picabia to Paris.
- With Paul Poiret's encouragement, Schiaparelli began designing and producing clothing in Paris, where she eventually launched her own company in 1927. Adorably referred to as "Schiap" by her close companions, she socialized with some of the most well-known figures of the era, including Greta Garbo, Christian Bérard, Marlene Dietrich, and Jean Cocteau.
- Her first collection consisted of sweaters adorned with surrealist trompe l'oeil images - a theme that was to become Schiaparelli's trademark. *(Sowray, B. (2012, April 1).)*

4.3. Early success and recognition

Schiaparelli's early successes were distinguished by a departure with conventional norms. Her fashion house quickly rose to prominence due to its innovative designs that challenged traditional notions of femininity. Her use of asymmetry and the iconic "shocking pink" color became her style's trademarks. Collaborations with artists such as Salvador Dal emphasized her out-of-the-box thinking, laying the groundwork for a career that defied expectations and left an indelible mark on the world of haute couture. These early successes not only established Schiaparelli as a trailblazer in an era of shifting attitudes and artistic experimentation, but also laid the groundwork for her unconventional approach.

5. Breaking Gender Norms

Elsa Schiaparelli's designs in the 1930s were a daring challenge to entrenched gender norms. This section delves into specific garments that defied traditional gender distinctions. Schiaparelli's creations during this period were revolutionary in their rejection of conventional gender expectations, whether through the incorporation of tailored elements traditionally associated with menswear or the use of unexpected materials.



Brooklyn Museum Costume Collection at The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1955

Schiaparelli boldly introduced tailored trouser suits for women, a departure from the time's predominant skirts and dresses. This design questioned the notion that women's fashion should adhere strictly to more traditional and restrictive silhouettes.

A strong military theme pervaded Schiaparelli's winter 1935–36 collection, which was influenced by the unpredictability of European politics. That year, several other designers included red coats in their winter collections, but Schiaparelli's understated, unconventional interpretation of a classic shape—the military greatcoat—hits home. The rigid silhouette displays Schiaparelli's unique sculptural sensibility, and the exposed seams are a byproduct of her careful attention to artistic detail and thoughtful design sense.



Brooklyn Museum Costume Collection at The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1984

The 1930s were a turning point in the history of fashion, and at the forefront stood Elsa Schiaparelli, a visionary designer who not only challenged traditional norms but also significantly contributed to a more inclusive and diverse fashion landscape. Her designs during this time period were groundbreaking, defying societal expectations and embracing diversity in a variety of ways.

An often overlooked Surrealist whose contribution to the movement is rich and pertinent, Schiaparelli was an artist who challenged conventional representations of femininity through playfulness, moving beyond the idea of women as objects of male consumption and transforming the female body into an independent entity that revelled in elegant sexual display. (Stent, S. D. (2011). *Women surrealists: Sexuality, Fetish, femininity and female surrealism.*)

Elsa Schiaparelli, guided by her unbridled creativity, launched her full-fledged rebellion against traditional silhouettes and concepts in 1927. From sportswear to haute couture, art, fragrance, and everything in between, the designer's groundbreaking creations laid the groundwork for a house with no boundaries. There was no distinction for Schiaparelli between clothes and costumes, between fashion as a mirror of everyday life and costume design as a staging, as the theatricalisation of life. Design was an artistic act for the Italian artist, which she accomplished through numerous collaborations with artists such as Salvador Dalí and Jean Cocteau.

Masculine and feminine are defined here not by the comfort of sportswear, but by extremely designed and rigorous silhouettes that are exaggerated in volume, decorations, and colors.



Shocking, 1938
Image Source: Vogue

Schiaparelli's designs frequently emphasized the natural form and promoted body positivity. Her designs embraced diverse body shapes and sizes by moving away from restrictive corsets and introducing silhouettes that allowed for comfort and movement, challenging the prevailing beauty standards.

As Svendsen suggests, Schiaparelli created clothing that was both practical and avant-garde. Schiaparelli's Surrealist clothing, on the other hand, literally and figuratively upended mainstream convention by referencing pre-existing ideas about a woman's sexuality and erotica. Her costumes explored (representations of) the female body by being overtly sexualized without baring too much flesh. Her sexuality was displayed in a methodical manner. Schiaparelli thus challenges conventional ideas of what could be regarded as "sexual" or "erotic" apparel. For this very reason, Schiaparelli is considered avant-garde; more than any other fashion designer, she was a trailblazer in the era of blending traditional notions of femininity and sexuality. (Lars Svendsen, *Fashion: A Philosophy* (London: Reaktion Books Ltd, 2006), p. 96.)

She used her own creative process to distill the unsettling dream-like imagery and thought-provoking ideas, fusing themes from current affairs, erotic fantasy, traditional and avant-garde art, and her own psyche into her designs. Her medium of creative expression was a repertoire of inventive devices: bold prints with unconventional imagery and colors, opulent embroideries, outsized and exposed zippers, unique buttons and ornaments ranging from the whimsical to the bizarre, and experimental fabrics with pronounced textures. *Reeder, J. G. (1AD, January 1). Elsa Schiaparelli (1890–1973): Essay: The Metropolitan Museum of Art: Heilbrunn timeline of art history.)*

Her bold color choices, especially the well-known "shocking pink," and her use of unusual materials like plastics and cellophane expanded the range of possibilities in fashion. "Shocking pink" evolved into a gender-, age-, and social status-neutral bridge connecting the avant-garde and the mainstream. The deliberate use of such a striking color scheme helped partially dismantle color-related gender stereotypes. By eschewing traditional fabrics and muted hues, people were able to express themselves more freely and break free from the constrictions of a limited range of aesthetic standards. This exploration served as a declaration that fashion need not be limited to the use of traditional materials and should also push the boundaries of creativity.

6. Surrealism

After World War I, a movement known as surrealism was born with the goal of defying social conventions and examining the unconscious. But the movement was dominated by men, with leaders like André Breton. Surrealist politics frequently obscured the voices and accomplishments of women by reflecting the viewpoints and experiences of male artists. Schiaparelli entered the Surrealist landscape as a fashion designer rather than a painter or poet, a field dominated by men.

Nonetheless, her creations challenged the established hierarchy within Surrealist circles and evolved into a distinct kind of capital. By working together with well-known male Surrealist artists, like Salvador Dalí, Schiaparelli broke down barriers between the art and fashion industries and made fashion a potent vehicle for political expression. In addition to creating fashionable pieces that are practical and feminine, Schiaparelli also plays with and modifies the central Surrealist trope of the fetishized female anatomy.

Collaboration between Schiaparelli and Dalí gave life to Surrealism; Dalí's paintings became alive and became wearable and practical art. While Schiaparelli is best known for her works with Dalí, she also collaborated with other Surrealists, such as Louis Aragon, Leonor Fini, Alberto Giacometti, Meret Oppenheim, and Elsa Triolet, creating clothing, jewellery, and perfume bottles. Her solo collection's designs stuck to the surrealist theme as well.

6.1. Changing Narratives of Power : Reimagining Surrealism



Fig. 1 - Elsa Schiaparelli (Italian, 1890-1973). Skeleton dress, 1938. Silk, cotton. London: Victoria and Albert Museum, T.394&A-1974. Given by Miss Ruth Ford. Source: [V&A](#)

In Schiaparelli's Skeleton Dress, the combination of materials used to create the garment creates an internal three-dimensional body structure that incorporates Dalí's interest in corporeality. The "skin tight" clothing of Schiaparelli creates the appearance of a "faux anatomy," or second skin. The simple design of the dress, which suggests a nude body and no clothes, highlights and conveys the wearer's personality. The garment takes on symbolic meaning, holding a collection of subliminal messages that mold personal identity. Essentially the choice of clothing comes to *'mean something and help say something about the person wearing the symbol'* (*Ibid*, p. 63.)

It is a potent creation that demonstrates that a body does not have to be completely nude to arouse desire or fetish by utilizing the power of suggestion, which can be just as potent as the presentation of a naked body.



The woman's body is depicted in the Tear Dress as a delicate object composed of delicate material. But if you look closely at the garment, you can see that it makes a bold statement that aims to elicit a strong response rather than a statement of weakness. presenting "*an imagery of torn and desecrated flesh,*" . (Svendson, p. 65.)



Collection of The Dalí Museum, St. Petersburg, FL (USA); Gift of A. Reynolds & Eleanor Morse 2000.24

The mural "Three Young Surrealist Women Holding In Their Arms the Skins of an Orchestra (1936)" by Dalí served as the model for the design. Svendson described the outcome as "a combination of the illusory and the real" because of her unique style. In contrast to the previously mentioned Skeleton Dress, the outcome is a flowing, ethereal, white dress with a pink print on the fabric. The design makes references to the desecrated woman and the act of rape in particular.

Similarly, the pink of the ripped panels of the dress, which symbolizes the injured nude flesh beneath the clothing, evokes murder or a violent attack. The woman has not been undressed despite attempts to do so; Schiaparelli's gown accentuates the skin instead of removing substantial sections of it.

Schiaparelli has chosen to highlight the woman's strength and vulnerability by confronting and refusing to conceal the violent attack that has occurred, even though she is aware of the patriarchal figurations that surround the nude female body. As a result, Schiaparelli's designs have evolved into something "*self-conscious, constructive, and critical,*" enabling fashion to serve as a language that connects the subconscious on the inside to the outside physical body. (Ibid, p. 53.)

7. Reshaping Schiaparelli: Daniel Rose Berry's Dialogue with Contemporary Culture

'The landscape of its legacy – the practical magic of its resonance – is something almost mythical in the wide geography of the fashion universe. Schiaparelli means an intimate and ancient relationship between art and fashion, in particular with the vernacular of a Surrealism dear to the heart of Elsa Schiaparelli herself. In the hands of Daniel Roseberry, this resonance pulses with an energy and freshness that regularly takes the breath away.'

- Tilda Swinton

Following ten years at Thom Browne, where he ultimately held the position of design director, Roseberry was quickly acclaimed as Elsa Schiaparelli's 21st-century progenitor, a designer capable of bringing the house's Surrealist affinities into the digital era and reinterpreting her ethereal iconography for a period more troubled by the renown and illusions of American pop culture. Roseberry was appointed creative director in 2019. He is described as "unnervingly symbiotic in his capacity to channel and take forward the sensibility of not only the house itself but also the person of Elsa Schiaparelli and the atmosphere of the fellowship around her" by Tilda Swinton, who Roseberry has frequently dressed.

In his initial days at Schiaparelli, Roseberry had little to no interest in utilising the archives. He felt as though it had already been the focal point for several years following its revival and required a modern take to reinvent the brand. It was only after he had merged his personal inspirations and started referencing the archives of the house did Schiaparelli truly emerge as a couture house of the future. (*In conversation. Daniel Roseberry for Schiaparelli. - issue 19. System Magazine. (2023, May 9).*)

‘I tried to re-establish the voice of the house and make it personal. When I felt that we had done that, I was able to return to Elsa’s work.’

In addition to paying homage to Elsa Schiaparelli, the founder of the Maison, and her love of Surrealism, Roseberry has gained recognition for his ability to revive some of the Maison's most cherished and influential codes and iconography during his tenure. However, he has also subverted many of those same codes, creating a new aesthetic vocabulary through his frequent use of gold jewelry and hardware, repurposed denim, and molded leather and metal breast plates and body parts. Similar to Schiaparelli, who was renowned for her technical advancements, Roseberry is especially enthusiastic about exploring novel or unconventional textiles and expanding the notion of what couture can—or ought to—be.

Schiaparelli uses surrealist jewelry that features grotesquely oversized body parts like toes and ears. Schiaparelli's signature and skill is his ability to make the unusual alluring and desirable. If Roseberry's clothing is surrealist, it's because of the unanticipated disarray of images, which seems more like a reflection of how images are disseminated in the twenty-first century than true avant-garde design. Roseberry isn't scared to incorporate in elements from other designers such as Jean Paul Gaultier or Christian Lacroix, It is this unexpected symphony of other artists with the inherent homage to Elsa's legacy that truly makes Schiaparelli the brand it has evolved to today .

To keep the founder's intentions alive in a new century, Roseberry has "learned to stay loose". "When you look at Elsa's process, it feels free and unburdened, and spontaneous," he says. "It's like the shower principle: that the best ideas come to you when you're not thinking about them, or when you're in the shower. I think her work has this free-wheeling intelligence that feels so ahead of its time.

It wasn't just about beauty, or of the 'line' of a dress. It was about a concept, an idea, a notion of reality. She would take this notion and bend it to her will."

In the end, Elsa's contributions to fashion were less about iconography and more about her unique personality and the unconventional ideas of a woman who was not trained in the more technical aspects of dressmaking, like exposed zippers and instinctive draping. Roseberry seeks to preserve that spirit of openness and investigation while modernizing it for the practical, cross-platform era.

8. Conclusion

Within the intricate fabric of fashion history, Elsa Schiaparelli stands out as a trailblazing icon who, via her innovative approach to design, transcended the limitations of her era. Schiaparelli was raised in an aristocratic Roman household, which prepared him for his distinctive blend of artistic sensibility and rebellious attitude. Her unique style emerged as she entered the fashion industry in the vibrant 1920s, characterized by an unrestrained use of color, avant-garde textiles, and a desire to subvert social conventions. The surrealist partnerships Schiaparelli had, especially with the renowned Salvador Dalí, represent a significant turning point in her story. The Lobster Dress, a surreal creation that demonstrated the collaboration between two creative minds, is the perfect example of the clothes they created together that broke the boundaries between fashion and art. Schiaparelli made an equally revolutionary contribution to gender inclusion in fashion. Her designs, with their androgynous aspects, offered a vision that highlighted both rebellion and elegance, breaking free from the confines of traditional gender norms. Not only did the iconic Schiaparelli pink become associated with her company, but it also became a symbol of empowerment.

In the present day, Daniel Rose Berry takes over as creative director of Schiaparelli, emulating the avant-garde style of his founder. Rose Berry's reinvention makes sure that Schiaparelli continues to be a beacon of creativity firmly entrenched in the spirit of contemporary haute couture, navigating the difficult dance between paying homage to history and satisfying the needs of the fashion world today.

Elsa Schiaparelli left behind a dynamic heritage of avant-garde creativity, gender liberty, and artistic disobedience. The enduring force of bravery and invention in the constantly changing world of high fashion is demonstrated by Schiaparelli's journey, as her influence continues to inspire modern designs while Daniel Rose Berry infuses the brand with a modern flair.

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